

Dossier B – Silk Road “Algorithmic Feed” Relay

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Article Draft – UNCORRECTED PROOFS

Author: Dr. Y. [REDACTED]

Site: WATCHTOWER COMPLEX 7 (“THOUSAND EYES”) – EASTERN PAMIRS

Estimated Period: 1st–3rd century CE

Subject: STRUCTURED MESSAGE RELAY AS EARLY ATTENTION-RANKING SYSTEM

Abstract

At Watchtower Complex 7, overlooking a key branch of the Silk Road, we uncovered an assemblage of wooden slips and parchment fragments bearing short messages from travellers, merchants, and envoys. Many are routine notices, but a subset contains **routing instructions and marginal commands** that governed how messages were copied, displayed, and prioritised. This suggests that the complex functioned as an **early algorithmic message relay**, where intermediaries ranked and amplified information according to perceived attention value.

1. The “board” and message types

Several fragments mention a “board” (variously in Greek, Bactrian, and local scripts) in the caravanserai courtyard where notices were posted:

Slip 7-15 (Greek, parchment):

“Of the news arriving today, place those concerning **bandits, plague, and wonders** at the top of the board.

Travellers will pay more for spaces in the upper row.

If three or more letters mention the same caravan, nail the most alarming one at eye level...”

These instructions establish:

- **Content categories** (danger, marvels) deemed inherently more engaging.
- A **positional hierarchy** on the board, with premium spots monetised.
- A crude **deduplication** logic: highlight whichever version of an event is most sensational.

2. Attention tracking

Another slip links message prominence to measures of attention:

Slip 9-03 (Bactrian, wood):

“Each time a traveller stops to read the red-ink notices, make a notch on the post.

At month’s end, send the tally to **the Circle**.

Those who pay for higher rows must prove they can hold many eyes.”

A vertical post beside the main board bears irregular clusters of notches at varying heights; the pattern fits this instruction. Some notches are marked with traces of red pigment, presumably tied to particular notice categories.

We have here:

- A simple **view counter** (physical notches for each viewing).
- Early **A/B testing**: red-ink notices vs. ordinary ink, with results reported to a central authority ("the Circle").

3. The "Thousand Eyes" icon

Above the boarding area, a plaster plaque shows a ring of nine carved eyes surrounding a shallow depression. Faint Sogdian graffiti nearby mentions a "*House of the Second Script*". The stylistic resemblance to the nine-eye seal from Uruk-North is striking, though the temporal and geographic distance is considerable.

Local oral traditions (collected in the 19th century) refer to the site as "**hezar chashm**" ("thousand eyes"), allegedly in reference to the many lookouts of the tower; however, no pre-modern text explains the nine-eye symbol directly.

[SECTION 3.3 – ICONOGRAPHIC ANALYSIS – MISSING FROM ARCHIVE COPY]

We cautiously propose that:

- The same motif may mark a **recurring, low-visibility group** that inserts itself at strategic information chokepoints (archives, watchtowers, later perhaps printing houses).
- "The Circle" that receives the attention tallies could be an administrative fiction—or the organisational name of that group.

No surviving document states what the Circle does with the data it receives; the entire processing layer remains undernarrated.